Aquifer Open Study Notes

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Ecclesiastes

Ecclesiastes 1:1

Ecclesiastes does not mention the Teacher's name (Qoheleth in Hebrew), but King David's son likely refers to Solomon (see also Ecclesiastes 1:12, 16; 2:4–9).

Ecclesiastes 1:2

Futility of futilities…Everything is futile (literally vapor of vapors): Whenever "meaningless" appears in this book, it translates the Hebrew word hebel, which means "breath" or "vapor." The Teacher concludes that everything is temporary and lacks meaning, like vapor.

Ecclesiastes 1:2–11

The Teacher starts by noting that every natural and historical activity has a repetitive cycle of coming and going, existing and not existing. This can cause some to feel that everything is meaningless. The Teacher quickly shifts from one topic to another and ends this section with the topic he began with, using a literary style that reflects the cycles he describes in nature and human history.

Ecclesiastes 1:3

The Hebrew phrase under the sun appears twenty-nine times in Ecclesiastes. The New Living Translation sometimes translates it as "here on earth" (Proverbs 2:18) or "in this world" (Proverbs 2:20). It suggests a view of life focused on earthly matters rather than God's perspective.

Ecclesiastes 1:4

Generations come and go, and individual lives often seem to pass without importance.

Ecclesiastes 1:7–8

The sea is never full, and we are never satisfied. This image shows how life can feel unfulfilling.

Ecclesiastes 1:11

There is no remembrance: We cannot rely on others to remember what we believe we have accomplished.

Ecclesiastes 1:12–2.26

The Teacher examines how wisdom, work, and pleasure relate to each other.

Ecclesiastes 1:13

What a miserable task God has laid: The harsh truths of human experience remind us of the Fall in Eden (Genesis 3). Ecclesiastes does not avoid sad topics like death, oppression, and loneliness. Instead, it faces them directly and includes them in realistic conclusions.

Ecclesiastes 1:14

a pursuit of the wind.: Life comes and goes quickly, just like the wind.

Ecclesiastes 2:1–11

The Teacher says seeking pleasure for its own sake is empty. Even great achievements are like smoke.

Ecclesiastes 2:3

- The Teacher realized that using wine to cheer himself was foolish, yet he did it while still seeking wisdom. He wanted to understand how to find happiness. This effort turned out to be pointless (Ecclesiastes 2:11).
- the few days of their lives: All human experiences are like "a breath."

Ecclesiastes 2:4

The Bible mentions Solomon's vineyards in Song of Solomon 8:11–12.

Ecclesiastes 2:4–8

Solomon built both small structures like porches and gates and large ones like entire cities (see 1 Kings 9:15–19). He mainly built these projects for his own enjoyment, including the palace and its related buildings (see 1 Kings 7:1–12).

Ecclesiastes 2:7

Solomon's slaves managed large herds and flocks. Caring for them used many resources (1 Kings 4:22–23; 9:20–21).

Ecclesiastes 2:8

- silver and gold and the treasure of kings and provinces: Solomon ruled from the Fertile Crescent, north and east of Israel, to Egypt's border in the south. He gained wealth in precious metals through trade, gifts from admiring rulers, and taxes from lands within his empire (1 Kings 4:21; 9:28; 10:14, 22–25; 1 Chronicles 29:4; 2 Chronicles 9:26–27).
- many concubines: Solomon had 700 wives and 300 concubines by the end of his reign (1 Kings 11:3).

Ecclesiastes 2:9

I became great: Compare 1 Kings 10:23.

Solomon's wisdom helped him gain power and wealth (see 1 Kings 3:2–14; 4:20–34).

Ecclesiastes 2:10

For my heart took delight in all my work: The Teacher highlights a key theme: Joy comes from wise and diligent work (Ecclesiastes 5:12, 18–20).

Ecclesiastes 2:11

futile…nothing to be gained: Accomplishments may lead to hopelessness and discouragement because they lack lasting meaning (Ecclesiastes 2:18–23).

Ecclesiastes 2:12

what more can the king's successor do than what has already been accomplished?: After the Teacher, no one will have a better way to compare wisdom and foolishness because nothing new will happen under the sun (Ecclesiastes 1:9–10).

Ecclesiastes 2:12–23

The Teacher now examines the value of wisdom (Ecclesiastes 2:12–17) and hard work (2:18–23). These, too, are futile (Ecclesiastes 2:17).

Ecclesiastes 2:13–14

wisdom exceeds folly: Wisdom is useful because it helps navigate life successfully. However, it cannot prevent death or give life meaning (Ecclesiastes 2:15–16).

Ecclesiastes 2:15–16

- The fate of the fool will also befall me. What then have I gained by being wise?: Since the lives of both are short, the conclusion is that everything is meaningless.
- both will be forgotten: Future generations will not remember us or our achievements, so our efforts will amount to nothing (compare Ecclesiastes 1:11; 9:13–16).

Ecclesiastes 2:17–20

The Teacher began to dislike life because of its:

- Sorrows (Ecclesiastes 1:18)
- Hard work (Ecclesiastes 2:18)
- Seeming pointlessness (Ecclesiastes 2:19–20)

Ecclesiastes 2:19

Foolish and destructive successors pose a greater threat to wise accomplishments than wise successors do. However, since the Teacher could not predict the type of successors he would have, his accomplishments felt meaningless to him. Solomon's immediate successor, his son Rehoboam, turned out to be foolish (see 1 Kings 12:1–20).

Ecclesiastes 2:21

- labored with wisdom, knowledge, and skill: Skill in work shows wisdom (for example, see Exodus 31:1–5).
- give his portion to a man who has not worked for it: A person with little personal investment tends to waste it or take foolish risks.

Ecclesiastes 2:24

this is from the hand of God: Do not overlook God's gifts, like enjoying food and work. Without God, these would not exist. We can be thankful and content.

Ecclesiastes 2:24–26

Even though life under the sun (Ecclesiastes 1:3) is like a vapor (2:23, futile), we should enjoy God's gifts of food, work, and wisdom.

Ecclesiastes 2:26

If a sinner becomes wealthy, it is meaningless because God takes the wealth away.

Ecclesiastes 3:1–8

To everything there is a season, and a time for every purpose under heaven: Wisdom knows that everything has its own time. Both in human activities and in nature (see Ecclesiastes 1:3–7). A wise person knows when to start any activity (Ecclesiastes 8:5). Opportunities do not last long (Ephesians 5:16; Colossians 4:5).

Ecclesiastes 3:2–8

- We cannot control when we are born or when we die (Ecclesiastes 8:8), but we must live wisely between those events.
- plant and…uproot: Make wise agricultural decisions during the natural seasons.
- In ancient Israel, times to kill included capital punishment and war.
- During mourning, people in the Near East often tore their clothes.
- There is a time to hate, even for God (Psalms 5:5; 11:5).

Ecclesiastes 3:9

gain from his toil?: See Ecclesiastes 3:12–13.

Ecclesiastes 3:9–14

Every activity has a right time (Ecclesiastes 3:1–8), but only God knows when that time is (Ecclesiastes 3:9–11). People should accept uncertainty and trust God, who rewards wise and righteous work with enjoyment.

Ecclesiastes 3:10

the burden that God has laid upon the sons of men: God made our work harder after humans rebelled against Him (Genesis 3:17–19). This burden is not too heavy for us to enjoy our work and its rewards (Ecclesiastes 3:11213).

Ecclesiastes 3:11

- He has made everything beautiful in its time: We can sometimes see this beauty in our work and the world. However, many people cannot see it. God keeps the understanding of how everything fits together for himself (see Romans 8:22–28).
- God has planted eternity, an awareness of the infinite, within each of us. This is enough for us to be in awe of him who is infinite and eternal, and enough to hope for eternal life after death.

Ecclesiastes 3:12–13

rejoice and do good while they live: Even though life and work can be hard, the Teacher's conclusion (repeated from Ecclesiastes 2:24) can still be true.

Ecclesiastes 3:14

Understanding that God's actions are final is a reason to respect and trust him. We should honor and value all that he does.

Ecclesiastes 3:15

what will be has already been: The same events repeat throughout history (Ecclesiastes 1:9–10) which is part of God's plan.

Ecclesiastes 3:16

the place of justice: In ancient Israel, local court proceedings took place at the city gates. The city's elders sat there to hear and decide legal matters (for example, see Ruth 4:1–12).

Ecclesiastes 3:16–5.7

This section discusses various topics, such as justice, humans and animals, oppression, moderation, companionship, politics, and worship.

Ecclesiastes 3:17

God will judge: Human injustices (Ecclesiastes 3:16) are temporary and God will correct them. The narrator repeats this to conclude the book (Ecclesiastes 12:14).

Ecclesiastes 3:19

When it comes to breathing and dying, people are like animals, but we have other advantages (for example, see Genesis 1:26–28).

Ecclesiastes 3:20

from dust…to dust: The Teacher talks about God's judgment on human rebellion in Eden (see Genesis 3:19).

Ecclesiastes 3:21

the spirit of man rises: Compare Ecclesiastes 12:7.

Ecclesiastes 3:22

enjoy his work: Work is now a separate source of enjoyment, different from food and drink (compare Ecclesiastes 2:24–25; 3:12–13).

Ecclesiastes 4:1

all the oppression: Oppression is widespread in society. It occurs in families, religions, workplaces, governments, and from foreign powers.

Ecclesiastes 4:2

In places with oppression, the dead are better off than the living. The dead no longer suffer mistreatment.

Ecclesiastes 4:4

Most people are driven to succeed by competition. Since the rewards have no real value, the Teacher suggests moderation (Ecclesiastes 4:5–6) instead of envy.

Ecclesiastes 4:5–6

Fools do not try to succeed and end up poor. Others work frantically, using all their time and effort, to chase temporary wealth they will not have time to enjoy (compare Proverbs 23:4–5). Wise people practice moderation and contentment (tranquility).

Ecclesiastes 4:7–8

This lonely man is an example of the idea in Ecclesiastes 4:6.

Ecclesiastes 4:9–12

Two are better than one: The solitary man (Ecclesiastes 4:8) reminds us of the benefits of partnerships in business and personal life.

Ecclesiastes 4:13–14

Better is a…wise youth: Wisdom is valuable because it helps in real-life situations.

Ecclesiastes 4:15–16

A ruler's popularity is temporary and fleeting, like the wind.

Ecclesiastes 5:1

The house of God offers a chance for respectful words and thoughtful promises, but it is mainly a place for listening.

Ecclesiastes 5:3

many cares…many words: We should aim for moderation in our actions and speech (see Proverbs 10:19).

Ecclesiastes 5:4–5

Fulfill your vow: This is almost a direct quote from the law (Deuteronomy 23:21–23; see also Proverbs 12:22; 20:25). Vows to God were voluntary, but once made, you had to keep them.

Ecclesiastes 5:7

fear God: Respecting God is the basis for meaningful words and helpful actions (see Ecclesiastes 12:1; Proverbs 1:7).

Ecclesiastes 5:8–9

for one official is watched by a superior, and others higher still are over them. The produce of the earth is taken by all; the king himself profits from the fields: The New Living Translation sees these verses as saying that bureaucracy causes oppression instead of justice, even up to the king (see also 1 Samuel 8:11–18). This is not surprising because bureaucracies often work this way. Others interpret the verses to mean that the king and his officials oversee to prevent injustice and oppression. The first view aligns more with the Teacher's realistic perspective.

Ecclesiastes 5:10

We are spiritual and physical beings, so possessions and wealth cannot fully satisfy us.

Ecclesiastes 5:12

The sleep of the worker is sweet: Hard work and balance create a peaceful, productive life. Chasing wealth causes unnecessary worries (Ecclesiastes 5:3).

Ecclesiastes 5:13–14

wealth hoarded…wealth lost: Possessions are temporary and can disappear for many reasons.

Ecclesiastes 5:16–17

Working just to gain possessions is like chasing the wind; it causes frustration, discouragement, and anger.

Ecclesiastes 5:18–20

The advice for enjoying life is clear: Enjoy your food, drink, and work. Appreciate them as gifts from God.

Ecclesiastes 6:1–2

This parable of the "unfortunate man" is similar to Ecclesiastes 4:7–8 and 5:13–17. It is a sad tragedy when someone succeeds but cannot enjoy their success. This person misses the only real benefit of success.

Ecclesiastes 6:3–6

a hundred children and live for many years: The blessings of old age and children mean nothing if life is not enjoyable or does not end well with a proper burial. It is better to be stillborn than to live a life full of unhappiness.

Ecclesiastes 6:7

People often feel unsatisfied with what they have, regardless of the amount (compare Ecclesiastes 5:10).

Ecclesiastes 6:8–9

What advantage, then, has the wise man over the fool?: They have an advantage if they enjoy and are content with what the Lord has given them.

Ecclesiastes 6:10

- Whatever exists was named long ago: See Romans 8:29; Ephesians 1:5, 11.
- it is known what man is: See Psalms 139:15–16.
- he cannot contend with one stronger than he: See Romans 9:20–24.

Ecclesiastes 6:10–7.22

God's control over everything is serious, but it gives us hope.

Ecclesiastes 6:11

For the more words, the more futility: Compare with Proverbs 10:19 and Proverbs 17:28.

Ecclesiastes 6:12

- Who knows?... Who can tell?: These questions have already been answered. We should spend our days living wisely, enjoying our work, and appreciating God's gifts (Ecclesiastes 2:13–14, 24; 3:22; 5:18). What will happen on this earth has already happened (Ecclesiastes 1:9, 10; 3:15).
- like a shadow: Compare Psalms 39:4–6; 90:3–6, 10–12; 109:23; 144:4.

Ecclesiastes 7:1

- It is better to seek a good reputation for wisdom and righteousness than to pursue luxuries like expensive perfume (Proverbs 22:1; 28:6).
- one's day of death is better than his day of birth: There is relief when life's troubles end. Life's difficulties can make one look forward to the peace of death (Ecclesiastes 1:18; 2:22; 4:2–3; 12:1).

Ecclesiastes 7:1–4

These proverbs are like the sayings in the Book of Proverbs.

Ecclesiastes 7:2–6

It is unwise to engage in carefree fun when wisdom calls for serious reflection on death (see also Ecclesiastes 2:12–13).

Ecclesiastes 7:3–4

good for the heart: Thinking clearly about death helps us understand the seriousness of God's curse on sin and shows us the importance of enjoying life wisely (Ecclesiastes 9:10).

Ecclesiastes 7:5–6

Praise from a fool and enjoying a fool's laughter are temporary and worthless. Criticism from a wise person can lead to real benefits (Proverbs 17:10).

Ecclesiastes 7:8

It is better to finish a project with patience than to start it with boastful words.

Ecclesiastes 7:9

anger settles in the lap of a fool: Compare Proverbs 14:29 and 29:11. See the "Anger" Theme Note.

Ecclesiastes 7:11–12

- Wisdom and money are powerful tools for gaining benefits.
- wisdom preserves the life of its owner: See Ecclesiastes 7:17; Proverbs 10:2; 11:4.

Ecclesiastes 7:13

God's powerful actions cannot be resisted; trying to oppose or escape his plans is pointless.

Ecclesiastes 7:14

Enjoying prosperity is good, but these gifts do not last. A wise person accepts God's control in everything (see Philippians 4:11–13).

Ecclesiastes 7:16

No matter how hard we work, there is always more to do, and we might harm ourselves in the process.

Ecclesiastes 7:17

Do not be excessively wicked: Foolish wickedness can lead to an early death (for example, 1 Samuel 25).

Ecclesiastes 7:19

the wise man: For example, see Ecclesiastes 9:14–15; 2 Samuel 20:15–22.

Ecclesiastes 7:20

no righteous man...never sins: See 1 Kings 8:46; Proverbs 20:9; Romans 3:23.

Ecclesiastes 7:22

It is good to forgive and be kind when others make mistakes or say something wrong.

Ecclesiastes 7:23–25

it was beyond me: The Teacher could not find the wisdom or reasons he sought. Such reasons are hidden in God's mind (Ecclesiastes 3:11; 8:17).

Ecclesiastes 7:26

a woman who is a snare: Compare Proverbs 5; 6:20–7:27.

Ecclesiastes 7:28

The New Living Translation adds the phrase "is virtuous" (based on Ecclesiastes 7:29) to clarify the verse.

Virtue is very rare. The Teacher found only a few virtuous men and no virtuous women in his experience.

Ecclesiastes 7:29

After much searching, the Teacher found that humanity's decline from God's created order (Genesis 1:27–28; 2:23–25; 3:1–19) was repeated by Adam and Eve's descendants (compare Romans 3:10–18, 23).

Ecclesiastes 8:1

the sternness of his face is changed: Anxiety, anger, sorrow, and frustration can make a face look stern, but enjoying life and gaining wisdom will brighten it.

Ecclesiastes 8:2

because of your oath before God: Compare Ecclesiastes 5:2–6; 1 Kings 2:41–43.

Ecclesiastes 8:3–4

It is pointless to plot against the king because he has great power and can do anything he wants.

Ecclesiastes 8:6

there is a right time...to every purpose: Wise people will be ready when the right moment comes (see Ecclesiastes 3:1–8; Ephesians 5:16).

Ecclesiastes 8:7–8

Our strength, goodness, and wisdom cannot prevent disasters, so choosing wickedness would be pointless.

Ecclesiastes 8:9–11

In this world, unfairness often wins. It can be frustrating when bad people seem to succeed.

Ecclesiastes 8:12–13

Injustice is temporary and does not disrupt God's plans for justice (Ecclesiastes 3:16–17; 12:14). In the end, wickedness does not succeed.

Ecclesiastes 8:15

- The Teacher's conclusion is familiar (Ecclesiastes 2:24–25; 3:12–13, 22; 5:18–20; 6:9). Despite tragedies and hard work, we can enjoy life and be happy.
- In Hebrew, the word translated as having fun means finding enjoyment in daily activities, not seeking pleasure or entertainment for its own sake.

Ecclesiastes 8:16–17

A person could spend all their time searching for answers, but some reasons will remain unclear. For example, God's justice can be mysterious.

Ecclesiastes 8:16–9.12

From observing life, it seems death often lacks meaning. Why do some people die while others live longer? God's decision on this is unpredictable (Ecclesiastes 7:13–14).

Ecclesiastes 9:1

Man does not know what lies ahead: There is no promise that doing good will bring rewards in this life (see Ecclesiastes 3:17–22; 8:10–15; 12:14).

Ecclesiastes 9:2

Everyone's fate is to eventually die.

Ecclesiastes 9:3

When authorities delay punishments, including death, people may continue their reckless behavior and increase their wrongdoing and foolishness.

Ecclesiastes 9:4–6

Hope for enjoyment exists only if the person hoping is alive. So, it is better to be alive (compare Ecclesiastes 6:3; 7:1).

Ecclesiastes 9:7–10

Death will happen to everyone, but it is good to enjoy life.

Ecclesiastes 9:10

in Sheol: In the Old Testament, Sheol is where the dead reside. It is not always linked to punishment.

Ecclesiastes 9:11

chance: We cannot control the outcome (compare Ecclesiastes 7:13).

Ecclesiastes 9:13–18

This poor man's wise action was effective. Wisdom is better than power, strength, or weapons (see Ecclesiastes 4:13; 7:9, 19; 10:4). However, deserving people are not always honored, and even wise individuals are sometimes forgotten (see Ecclesiastes 2:16; 4:16).

Ecclesiastes 9:18–10.1

one sinner destroys...a little folly outweighs: A little foolishness can ruin things. Sin and foolishness can quickly undo much good.

Ecclesiastes 10:2–3

These two proverbs highlight the foolishness of unwise people. They make poor choices, and their actions reveal their lack of wisdom.

Ecclesiastes 10:4

A ruler is anyone who has authority.

Ecclesiastes 10:5–7

Giving power to those who cannot use it wisely is a big mistake. Favoritism, nepotism, extortion, and bribery can put reckless people in powerful positions.

Ecclesiastes 10:7

slaves on horseback...princes go on foot: Compare Proverbs 19:10.

Ecclesiastes 10:8–9

Every activity needs wisdom. People show wisdom by taking safety precautions in their jobs, but some risk always remains.

Ecclesiastes 10:10

skill produces success: In every job, tools must be in good condition to work well. Sharpening a dull ax is wise for those who rely on it for their livelihood.

Ecclesiastes 10:11

One reason to charm a snake is to prevent it from biting, but a snake charmer risks a bite before charming it. Some jobs are so dangerous that smart people avoid them completely.

Ecclesiastes 10:12

Fools face ruin from making foolish promises, giving false testimony, and angering the wrong people (see 5:6; Proverbs 17:20; 18:6–7; 19:5, 9).

Ecclesiastes 10:14

- the fool multiplies words: Fools often speak about nothing important (see Ecclesiastes 5:3; 6:11; Proverbs 10:19; 17:28).
- who can tell him what will come after him?: Wise people avoid foolish talk and its consequences (see James 4:13–16).

Ecclesiastes 10:15

People who rarely work get tired quickly when they try to do it.

Ecclesiastes 10:15–20

The audience for this speech might have been a group of government workers. How should a leader govern when power and wealth lead to a lack of responsibility?

Ecclesiastes 10:16–17

- A servant does not have leadership skills.
- feast at the proper time: Wise leaders relax only after completing their work, not in the morning before starting. Lazy leaders weaken a society or organization.

Ecclesiastes 10:18

Delaying roof repairs causes rafters to sag and eventually ruins the home (see Proverbs 12:27; 20:4). Government corruption has a similar impact (Ecclesiastes 10:15–16).

Ecclesiastes 10:19

money is the answer for everything: It helps you get what you want or need in this world (see Ecclesiastes 7:11–12).

Ecclesiastes 10:20

It is often a mystery how others know what we have said. To manage our reputation, we should manage our thoughts.

Ecclesiastes 11:1–2

We should invest our resources instead of hoarding them, even if we cannot control the outcomes.

Ecclesiastes 11:1–6

All profitable activities involve risk. We should act wisely and trust God for the outcome.

Ecclesiastes 11:3

- clouds...rain: We can often predict what will happen.
- a tree...will lie: Our actions sometimes have permanent consequences.

Ecclesiastes 11:5

God's actions are often unpredictable and mysterious. Our task is to work whenever we have the chance (see Proverbs 12:11; 24:27).

Ecclesiastes 11:9

Young people should enjoy their youth fully. They should also remember they will answer to God, so they should avoid foolish behavior.

Ecclesiastes 11:10

Youth, like life, is enjoyable and beneficial but does not have lasting significance. It is a brief moment that quickly passes.

Ecclesiastes 12:1–2

Remember your Creator: Reverence for God can provide wisdom (Proverbs 1:7) and guidance on what is beneficial in life and pleasing to God at judgment (Ecclesiastes 12:13–14). It is better to remember God when young, as wisdom can greatly impact life's outcomes.

Ecclesiastes 12:1–7

This beautiful prose poem, rich with Hebrew metaphors, describes the painful decline that comes with aging. It continues from Ecclesiastes 11:7–10.

Ecclesiastes 12:3

The New Living Translation explains the Hebrew metaphors like:

- keepers of the house (guards)
- strong men
- those grinding (servants)
- those watching through windows (women)

It also interprets these poetic elements as:

- Legs
- Shoulders
- Teeth
- Eyes

Ecclesiastes 12:5

In the ancient Near East, people knew the caperberry as a love-enhancing food.

Ecclesiastes 12:6

- The silver cord and the golden bowl, like human life, are very valuable.
- The body is like a simple clay jar that is fragile and easily broken (compare Isaiah 29:16; Jeremiah 19:1, 10–11; 22:28; 2 Corinthians 4:7).

Ecclesiastes 12:7

- dust returns to the ground: See Genesis 2:7; 3:19.
- The idea that the spirit will return to God who gave it suggests a belief in an afterlife (compare Ecclesiastes 3:21; see "The Afterlife" Theme Note).

Ecclesiastes 12:8

This almost exact repetition of Ecclesiastes 1:2 summarizes the Teacher's conclusion.

Ecclesiastes 12:9

Even as king (Ecclesiastes 1:1), the Teacher made time to study wisdom. He gathered and organized proverbs (see also 1 Kings 4:29–34; Proverbs 1:1; 10:1; 25:1).

Ecclesiastes 12:9–14

This final note by the editor (see "Author and Recipients" in the Book Introduction) shows respect for the Teacher. It urges readers to apply the Teacher's lessons and shares the editor's conclusion from studying the Teacher (Ecclesiastes 12:13–14).

Ecclesiastes 12:11

- goads…firmly embedded nails: Sometimes, painful lessons guide us to paths we prefer to avoid.
- a single Shepherd: This word might refer to God as the shepherd of his people (Psalm 23:1; Isaiah 40:11). The sentence could also compare the wise person's words to a shepherd's work in caring for his flock.

Ecclesiastes 12:12

A balanced approach to writing and studying wisdom allows time to use it and enjoy its benefits.

Ecclesiastes 12:13–14

The editor concludes from studying the Teacher's work that we should fear God (see Ecclesiastes 3:14; 5:7; 7:18; 8:12–13). This means we must obey his commands, because everything we do will face judgment (see Ecclesiastes 11:9; 2 Corinthians 5:10; Hebrews 9:27).